

DO



Group the following types of knowledge:

- Knowing how to speak Latvian
- Knowing Robert Theofilopoulos
- Knowing how to make a pavlova
- Knowing that boron is the fifth element on the Periodic Table
- Knowing the city of Beijing
- Knowing the taste of garlic
- Knowing that David Hume was a Scottish philosopher
- Knowing how to repair a bicycle
- Knowing that monotremes are mammals which lay eggs
- Knowing the music of ABBA

You may have decided, along with many thinkers, that there are three broad categories of knowledge represented above: practical knowledge ('knowing how'), knowledge by acquaintance ('knowing of') and factual knowledge ('knowing that').

Practical knowledge is knowledge of how to do something – speaking a language, making a dessert, fixing a bicycle. This knowledge involves knowing how to perform some task but may not involve detailed understanding of the actions involved in the task. For example, you may know how to ride a bike but giving detailed instructions to someone on how to do this might prove challenging. You know how to speak English, but if you learnt it at a very young age you may struggle to explain its intricacies to a non-native speaker. This suggests that practical knowledge may be independent of our ability to explain it or be conscious of exactly what we know.

Knowledge by acquaintance is knowing a person, place or thing because we have encountered them or it. We may know Beijing because we've been there, we may know Robert because we've met him a few times, and we may know the taste of garlic because we've tasted it often enough to be familiar with its qualities. Again, we may struggle to articulate precisely what it is that we know in these cases. We can 'know' Robert while actually knowing very few facts about him, we may find it hard to describe garlic's distinctive flavour, and we may recognise an ABBA song if we hear one but not know any of their songs' titles or lyrics.

Factual knowledge is knowing that something is the case: that Hume was a philosopher, that monotremes lay eggs and that boron is a chemical element, fifth on the Periodic Table. Unlike the other two categories of knowledge, we can express this factual knowledge as a statement in language. It is easy to create a **proposition** – for example, 'Hume was a philosopher', 'Monotremes lay eggs', 'Boron is the fifth chemical element' – from this kind of knowledge.

For this reason, factual knowledge is also known as **propositional knowledge**. A proposition is a statement that asserts something – which may be true or false – about the world. Unlike practical knowledge or knowledge by acquaintance, factual knowledge involves holding a **belief**. A belief is a thought that represents the world in a particular way, claiming that something is the case. This may be true or false. This is why philosophers have traditionally been more interested in factual knowledge than in the other two types – because it involves beliefs that can be expressed as propositions and which may be either true or false. Therefore our next section will consider the nature of factual knowledge.

FACTUAL KNOWLEDGE

A **fact** is something that actually *is* the case about the world. A fact cannot be true or false, it just *is*. However, whether objective facts can actually exist has been called into question by some of our studies in the last Chapter. Since Immanuel Kant (Famous Philosopher File p.111) and even back to Plato (Famous Philosopher File pp.93-94), philosophers have debated the issue of whether humans are actually equipped to possess objective knowledge of an external world 'out there'.

But putting aside the realism/anti-realism debate (see Chapter 3, Theme 1, p.112), what does it mean for something to be **true**? We will be exploring this question in later sections, but one popular suggestion is that in cases of truth, a belief, the proposition about it and the circumstances observed in the world all match up. For example, when Herbert has a belief that 'My phone is in my pocket' and his phone actually *is* in his pocket, Herbert's belief and the proposition that expresses it are factual and true.

A shorthand has been developed for considering propositional knowledge more easily: 'S knows that P'. Here 'S' stands for the subject – the person who knows (for example, Herbert) – and 'P' is the proposition (for example, that his phone is in his pocket). Philosophers have then asked, what are the *conditions* that must be satisfied in order for us to claim that 'S knows that P' (Herbert knows that his phone is in his pocket)?

DO

1. What would you suggest are the *conditions that must be satisfied* for a belief to be true (i.e. for a proposition to express factual knowledge)?
2. Write a list of five things that you *know* and five things that you *believe*.
3. What is the case when you *know* something compared with just *believing* it?
4. How would you distinguish between *knowledge* and *belief*?

